

A DECADE OF DELIVERANCE

STAKEHOLDERS WEIGH IN ON THE EVOLUTION AND IMPACT OF A TOURNAMENT THAT HAS CHANGED THE FACE OF KABADDI FOREVER.

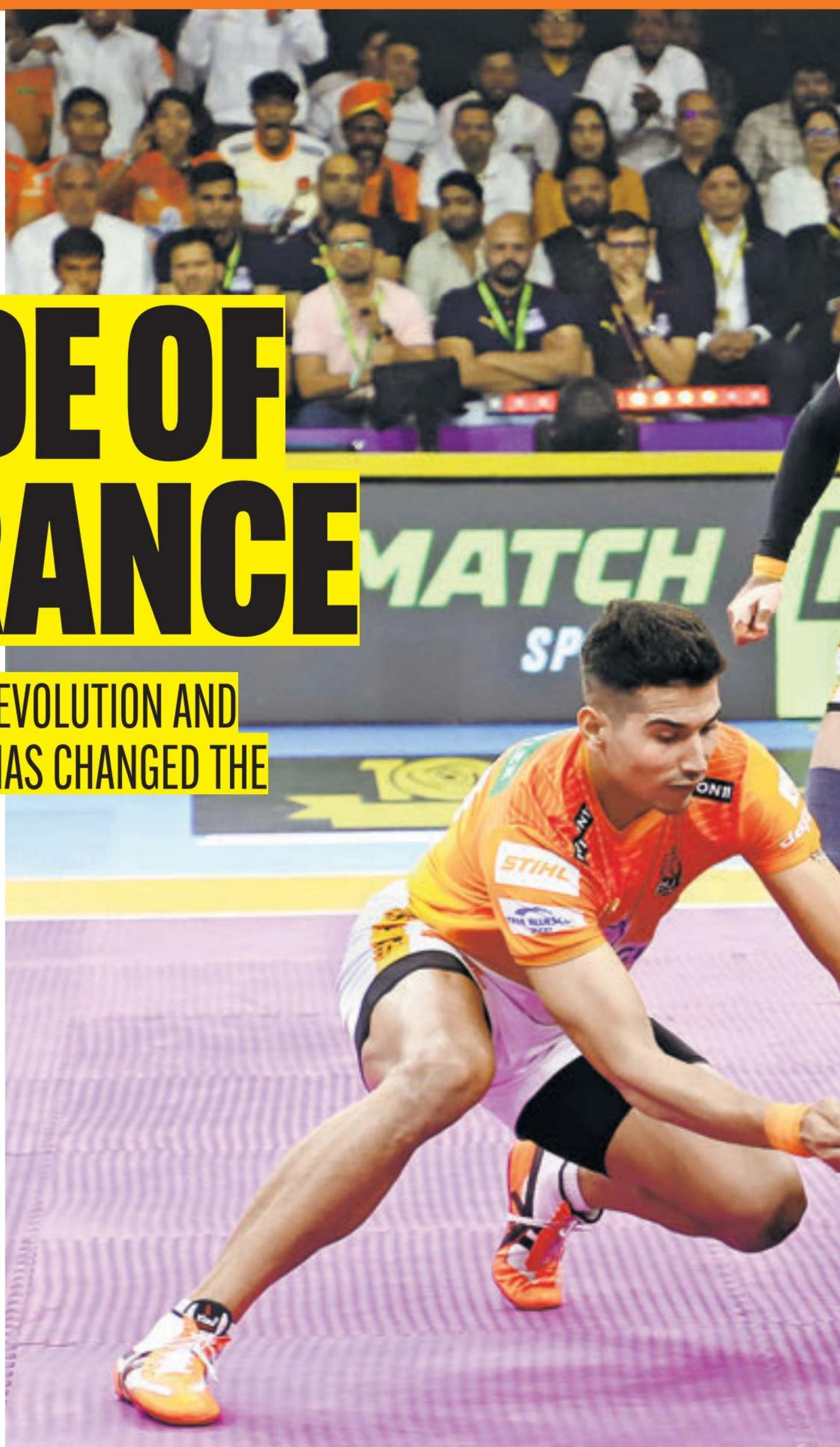
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In 2010, young men in Bijnor, Uttar Pradesh, particularly those inclined towards sports, had two main career paths before them: joining the Armed Forces or the Police. Rahul Chaudhari was no exception. A skilled athlete who wasn't particularly interested in academics (despite an aptitude for maths), Chaudhari found joy in sport, especially kabaddi.

"Par haath, pair toot gaye toh? (What if you break your limbs?)," his father would often say, admonishing him, especially for playing the sport he would later become synonymous with. Like many kabaddi players before and after him, Chaudhari came from a farming family, where seeking work outside agriculture was considered unconventional.

"We would look for jobs that offered 40-50,000 rupees a month. With that, you had to manage not only your family commitments but also dedicate resources to diet and training. Kabaddi is fortunate to have an entity like Pro Kabaddi League (PKL). Otherwise, players would never be in a position to give this sport their all," Chaudhari tells *Sportstar*.

He recalls a time when he sought out tournaments in nearby districts that offered a



Bullet motorcycle as the prize for the top raider. "I had enough confidence to seek these competitions out because I knew I was going to come back with that bike."

That love eventually grew into a love for cars.

"I built a house with the money I earned from PKL. I got my brothers married and funded my own wedding. And yes, I got my share of cars. I bought an Audi. My father asked me why I was wasting money, but I told